

A Room Near the Sea

Book 3 of 10

For the first time in her life, she was alone. And that was all right.

CEFR Level A1 | Adult Graded Reader

Setting: A small hotel in a coastal town in Portugal.

November - quiet, off-season.

Genre: Personal Growth / Travel

Characters

- Mia - 35. Secondary school teacher. Quiet, careful, a little afraid of being alone.
- Dona Rosa - 68. The hotel owner. Warm, direct, full of life.
- Rafael - 40. A painter staying at the hotel. Calm and kind.

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The room is small. There is a white bed, a small table, and a chair near the window. From the window, Mia can see the sea. It is November. The town is quiet. The beach is empty. Mia is alone. This is the first time in her life that she is really alone - in a hotel room in a country she does not know. She does not know how she feels about this.

Six months ago, Mia and her boyfriend Dan wanted to come to Portugal together. But two months ago, Dan said: 'I want to stop. I am sorry.' So Mia did not cancel the trip. She came alone. It was not easy. At the airport she almost went home. On the plane she did not eat. But now she is here. 'I am actually here,' she says to herself.

In the morning, Mia goes down to breakfast. A woman comes out of the kitchen - short and strong, white hair, dark bright eyes. 'Good morning! You are the English girl?' 'British. Yes.' 'I am Rosa. Sit down. Do you like eggs?' 'Yes.' 'Good. I make them well.' Rosa goes back to the kitchen. Mia smiles. It is the first time she smiles today.

After breakfast, Mia goes to the small garden behind the hotel. A man is sitting at the garden

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Mia arrives at a small guesthouse by the sea.

table. He has a sketchbook on his knees and he is drawing - slowly, carefully. He looks up. 'Hello. I am Rafael.' 'Mia.' 'Are you here for long?' 'A week.' 'Me too.' He goes back to his drawing. Mia sits on the other chair. They say nothing more. But it is not uncomfortable.

After lunch, Mia goes for a walk on the beach. It is long and grey. The sea is dark. The wind is cold. Mia walks and walks with no phone in her hand. She just looks at the water. She thinks about Dan, about home, about her job. Then she stops thinking. She just walks. After one hour she sits on a rock and looks at the sea. She thinks she feels a little better.

That evening at dinner, Rosa sits down with Mia. She pours a small glass of wine. 'I came here alone too. Thirty years ago. I had nothing. Now I have this hotel. My life. It is enough.' 'Were you afraid?' 'Of course,' Rosa says. 'Always.' Mia thinks about this.

The next morning, Mia sees Rafael in the garden with paints. 'Can I look?' 'Yes.' His drawings are of the town - the streets, the old doors, the sea. They are quiet and careful. 'They are beautiful.' 'Thank you. I come here every year

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Mia unpacks in her quiet room with a sea view.

and always find something new to draw.' 'Even in November?' Mia looks at the grey sky. Rafael smiles. 'Especially in November. The light is softer. Less noise. More real.'

On the third day, Mia wakes up and feels empty. Sad. She thinks: I am thirty-five, alone in Portugal, my boyfriend left, my students do not listen, my flat in London is cold. She does not go to breakfast. At ten o'clock, someone knocks. It is Rosa. She has a tray with coffee and bread. 'You did not come down. So I come up.'

Rosa pours the coffee. 'Drink.' The coffee is strong and good. 'Now. What is the real problem?' Mia almost says 'nothing'. But she is tired of saying nothing. She tells Rosa about Dan, about the trip, about feeling lost. Rosa listens. When Mia finishes, Rosa says one thing: 'You are not lost. You are here. That is different.'

After Rosa leaves, Mia gets up, gets dressed, and goes out. The streets are narrow and old. The walls are yellow and blue. She buys a pastry from a small bakery - sugar and lemon. She sits on the steps of the old church in the sun. The sun is weak but warm on her face. She thinks: not lost. Here. She takes a photograph of the church. Then she

puts her phone away.

Rafael is on the cliff every morning for the light. Mia takes the path and finds him standing on the rocks, painting. She does not want to interrupt. But Rafael hears her and waves. 'Come and look.' On the canvas, there is a half-finished painting of the sea. The same sea Mia can see. But on the canvas it looks more alive.

They stand on the cliff and talk. Rafael tells her he is an art teacher in Lisbon. Mia laughs. 'I am also a secondary school teacher!' 'What do you teach?' 'English.' 'Of course.' He smiles. 'We are the same.' 'But you paint,' Mia says. 'I don't do anything creative.' 'You came here alone,' Rafael says. 'That is creative.' Mia does not know what to say. She just looks at the sea.

On day five, Mia wakes up early. She goes down before Rosa opens the kitchen. She sits in the dining room and writes in a small notebook - not a diary, just words. Things she sees: the colour of the sea, the sound of the wind, the smell of Rosa's coffee. When Rosa comes in, she looks at Mia. 'You look different today.' 'I feel different,' Mia says. Rosa nods. 'Good.'

On the last evening, Mia has dinner with Rosa and Rafael. Rosa makes chicken and potatoes and opens a bottle of local wine. They sit at the big table, talk, eat, and laugh. Mia thinks: six days ago I was afraid to come here. Now I do not want to leave. After dinner they sit in the garden. The night is cold but the stars are clear. 'I want to come back,' Mia says. 'Good,' Rosa says. 'Your room will be here.'

In the morning, Mia packs her bag. There is a knock at the door - Rafael, with something in his hand. It is a small drawing: the cliff, the sea, and a small figure standing on the rocks, looking out. 'Is that me?' 'It could be anyone. But yes. It is you.' The figure is small. But she stands straight. She looks out at the sea. 'Thank you,' Mia says. She carefully puts the drawing in her bag.

Rosa is at the door when Mia comes down with her bag. They hug. Rosa is short but she hugs hard. 'You are a good woman,' Rosa says. 'You just forget sometimes.' Mia laughs - a real laugh. She gets into the taxi and looks out of the window. Rosa waves once. Then she goes inside. The hotel gets small. Then it is gone. But Mia keeps looking at the place where it was.

The airport is loud. Screens, bags, long queues at coffee shops. Mia finds her gate and sits down. She takes out Rafael's drawing - the small figure on the cliff. She thinks about the six days: the walks, Rosa's coffee, the cliff, the conversations. A week ago she almost did not come. She folds the drawing carefully and puts it in the front pocket of her bag. Close. Easy to find.

London is grey and wet. Mia's flat is cold when she opens the door. She turns on the heating. She puts her bag on the floor and looks around. Same flat. Same walls. Same life. But Mia feels different. She goes to the window. A grey London sky. Cars. People walking fast. She thinks: I was in Portugal a week ago. I will go back.

On Monday, Mia stands in front of her class. Normally she starts with the textbook. Today she does something different. 'Have you ever been to a place that changed you? Tell me about it.' The class is quiet. Then one student puts up a hand. Then another. Then another. Mia smiles. She takes out her notebook.

That evening Mia takes the drawing out of her bag. She finds a small frame in a drawer. It fits perfectly. She puts it on the wall next to the

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In the evening, Mia sits by the window and feels at peace.

window: the small figure, the cliff, the sea. She thinks: coming here alone is creative. You are not lost. You are here. Outside it is raining. The London sky is dark. But in Mia's flat there is a small picture of a woman on a cliff, looking out at the sea. And Mia is not afraid anymore.

Story Vocabulary

The words below are collected from the story. They are given together so the reading pages stay like a real story book.

1. room	oda	2. window	pencere
3. beach	plaj	4. November	Kasım
5. alone	yalnız	6. boyfriend	erkek arkadaş
7. cancel	iptal etmek	8. trip	yolculuk
9. airport	havalimanı	10. almost	neredeyse
11. dining room	yemek salonu	12. short	kısa boylu
13. bright	parlak, canlı	14. British	Britanyalı
15. eggs	yumurta	16. garden	bahçe
17. sketchbook	eskiz defteri	18. drawing	çizim yapıyor
19. accent	aksan	20. uncomfortable	rahatsız edici
21. walk	yürüyüş	22. grey	gri
23. wind	rüzgar	24. rock	kaya
25. a little better	biraz daha iyi	26. dinner	akşam yemeği
27. pours	döker	28. in front of	önüne
29. enough	yeterli	30. afraid	korkmuş
31. paints	boyalar	32. drawings	çizimler
33. especially	özellikle	34. softer	daha yumuşak
35. noise	gürültü	36. wakes up	uyanır

37. empty	boş, anlamsız	38. flat	daire
39. tray	tepsi	40. come down	aşağıya inmek
41. strong	güçlü, sert (kahve)	42. real problem	asıl sorun
43. tired of	... den bıkmış	44. feeling lost	kaybolmuş hissetmek
45. finishes	bitirir	46. narrow	dar
47. bakery	fırın	48. pastry	börek, pasta
49. church	kilise	50. steps	merdivenler
51. cliff	kayalık, uçurum	52. canvas	tuval
53. interrupt	bölmek	54. waves	el sallar
55. alive	canlı	56. secondary school	ortaokul / lise
57. art teacher	resim öğretmeni	58. creative	yaratıcı
59. the same	aynı	60. early	erken
61. notebook	defter	62. sound	ses
63. smell	koku	64. nods	başını sallar
65. chicken	tavuk	66. bottle	şişe
67. local	yerel	68. leave	ayrılmak
69. stars	yıldızlar	70. packs	bavulunu toplar
71. figure	figür, siluet	72. stands straight	dik durur
73. carefully	dikkatle	74. hug	sarılmak
75. shoulder	omuz	76. forget	unutmak

77. waves once	bir kez el sallar	78. gone	gitmiş
79. queues	kuyruklar	80. gate	kapı, uçuş kapısı
81. folds	katlar	82. front pocket	ön cep
83. close	yakın	84. wet	ıslak
85. heating	ısıtma sistemi	86. different	farklı
87. normally	normalde	88. textbook	ders kitabı
89. puts up a hand	elini kaldırır	90. another	bir diğeri
91. frame	çerçeve	92. drawer	çekmece
93. fits	uyuyor	94. raining	yağmur yağıyor
95. anymore	artık		

After-Reading Activities

1. Vocabulary Practice - Match the Words

Match each word with the correct meaning.

1. alone
- A. yeterli
2. afraid
- B. yalnız
3. narrow
- C. korkmuş
4. enough
- D. dar
5. cliff
- E. yaratıcı
6. creative
- F. kayalık
7. forget
- G. artık
8. anymore
- H. unutmak

2. Fill in the Blanks

Choose the correct word from the box and write it in the blank.

alone - afraid - creative - narrow - early - enough

1. Mia comes to Portugal _____. There is no one with her.
2. At the airport she was _____ and almost went home.
3. The streets in the town are _____ and old.
4. Rafael says: coming here alone is _____.
5. On day five, Mia wakes up _____.

6. Rosa says her life is _____. She does not need more.

3. Comprehension Questions

True or False? Write T or F.

1. Mia comes to Portugal with her boyfriend. ____
2. It is July when Mia arrives. ____
3. Rosa is the hotel owner. ____
4. Rafael is a doctor. ____
5. Mia writes in a notebook on day five. ____
6. Rafael gives Mia a drawing as a gift. ____

Short Answer Questions

7. Why did Mia come to Portugal alone?
8. What does Rosa say when Mia tells her she feels lost?
9. What does Rafael teach at school?
10. What does Mia write in her notebook?
11. What is in Rafael's drawing?
12. What does Rosa say to Mia at the hotel door?
13. What does Mia do differently at school on Monday?
14. What does Mia do with the drawing at home?
15. How does Mia feel at the end of the story?

Answer Key

(Alıştırmaları yaptıktan sonra bakınız.)

Match: 1-B 2-C 3-D 4-A 5-F 6-E 7-H 8-G

Fill in the Blanks: 1. alone 2. afraid 3. narrow 4. creative 5. early 6. enough

True / False: 1. F 2. F 3. T 4. F 5. T 6. T

7. Her boyfriend Dan ended their relationship, but she didn't cancel the trip.

8. 'You are not lost. You are here. That is different.'

9. Art.

10. Things she sees - the colour of the sea, the sound of the wind, the smell of coffee.

11. The cliff, the sea, and a small figure (Mia) looking out.

'12. 'You are a good woman. You just forget sometimes.'

13. She asks students to talk about a place that changed them.

14. She puts it in a frame and hangs it on the wall.

15. She is not afraid anymore.